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Sustainability Strategy

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List of acronyms

CCT	Cambodian Children's Trust
CCWC	Commune Committee for Women and Children
CPIMS	Child Protection Information Management System
DoSVY	Department of Social Affairs, Veterans and Youth Rehabilitation
EU	European Union
FCF	Family care first
FI	Friends International
IP	Implementing Partners
IT	Information technology
KII	Key informant interviews
LP	Lead Partner
MEF	Ministry of Economy and Finance
MoI	Ministry of Interior
MoSVY	Ministry of Social Affairs, Veterans and Youth Rehabilitation
MS	Mith Samlanh
NGO	Non-governmental organisation
RCIs	Residential care institutes
REACT	Responsive and Effective Child Welfare Systems Transformation
RGC	Royal Government of Cambodia
ROM	Results-oriented monitoring
SCI	Save the Children International
SNA	Sub-national authorities
TWGs	Technical working groups=
UN	United Nations
USAID	United States Agency for International Development
WCCC	Women’s and Children’s Consultative Committee

1. Executive Summary

Introduction

FCF | REACT is a network of organisations working together with the Royal Government of Cambodia (RGC) to support children to live in safe, nurturing family-based care. The network works collaboratively across RGC, primarily the Ministry of Social Affairs, Veterans and Youth Rehabilitation (MoSVY), and multiple agencies including local and international non-governmental organisations (NGOs), academic institutions, donors and United Nations (UN) agencies to promote and strengthen family-based care. The aim is to prevent children from being separated from their families and increase the number of children safely and successfully reintegrated into family-based care. The approach is twofold, firstly system strengthening, and secondly, direct provision of services to children and families. A results-oriented monitoring exercise of the EU-funded REACT component of the initiative was conducted in the first half of 2021, in anticipation of the funding phase completion at the end of the year. One recommendation was to develop a Sustainability Strategy to ensure adequate handover of achievements of the current phase and appropriately planning for the future.

The Sustainability Strategy has been developed by a consultant organisation, VBNK, working under the supervision of the Lead Partner, Save the Children International. The methodology was: document review; development of a sustainability tool and questionnaire; key informant interviews with 40 respondents from all the key agencies and stakeholder groups, with the exception of Ministry of Social Affairs, Veterans and Youth Rehabilitation; analysis and formulation of draft strategy; a workshop to get feedback from the key stakeholders; and, finalisation of the Strategy. A significant limitation was the short timeframe for conducting the study. This created pressure in terms of being able to arrange meetings with all the nominated respondents, and due to their busyness it was not possible to interview some key people before the development of the draft strategy. Their input was, therefore, given at the workshop before the Strategy was finalised.

The components of sustainability for the sphere of work undertaken in the FCF|REACT project are considered under three main headings, with sub-components as follows:

- ***Enabling conditions:*** Laws, *Prakas*, policies, guidelines, etc., vision and leadership, structure, communication and cooperation mechanisms, ownership and commitment
- ***Resources:*** Human, financial and technical
- ***Knowledge and skills:*** Networking and facilitation (including communication), technical and learning

Findings

All respondent groups were unanimous about the need to continue direct service provision to vulnerable children and families, not only reintegration but also monitoring and support to ensure placements do not break down, and on preventative. Additional themes considered essential were:

- Capacity development for system strengthening and for government and NGO staff
- The completion and roll out of the Social Service Workforce training curriculum
- Mechanisms and processes to provide technical support for MoSVY and at implementation level
- The provision of resources to do the work, including diversification of funding sources
- The development and implementation of inter-operable digital case management systems – OSCaR and PRIMERO

Respondents also noted some further activities that it would be desirable to continue if possible.

Legal framework: A critically important element of enabling conditions is having in place all the necessary laws, *Prakas*, policies, and guidelines to mandate and guide the work. These instruments can also be helpful in providing frameworks for the mobilisation and distribution of resources. The

respondents were all clear that, with the exception of the Law on National Adoption and Law on Child Protection, the legal framework is in place. The respondents were also unanimous that while the legal framework exists, much needs to be done to implement and operationalise the different legal instruments. Many noted that tools and systems have yet to be finalised, adopted and rolled out, and this in turn means that many implementers still have limited or no awareness and understanding of their roles, responsibilities and tasks.

Vision and leadership: When asked about their vision for the future of family-based care work and who should be leading the sector the respondents were again unanimous in their view that the RGC should be leading, both at national and sub-national levels. Many also saw the need for NGOs to continue having a role in both supporting government and direct implementation. Several respondents noted that the RGC being able to take on full leadership was dependent both on resources (funding) availability and the capacity of relevant staff. It was, additionally, noted that this necessary funding and capacity is not going to come into place by the end of this project, so it is not realistic to expect MoSVY to take on full responsibility for all aspects of the work in the short term. There needs to be a carefully negotiated and planned process of incremental transition as funding and capacity come into place, which should, eventually, also enable MoSVY and supporting agencies such as UNICEF and the key NGOs to agree any changes in how they work together in future.

Coordination structure*:* In general respondents felt that current coordination structures work well. Consideration of future needs was addressed at different levels: some focused on the national level, noting that MoSVY should lead through mechanisms such as the TWG with a high-level chairperson; others added that relevant UN agencies and NGOs should also be involved. Likewise at sub-national level all thought it should be government lead, but some also mentioned the need for UN and NGO support, including the provision of financial support. There were some comments about the need for coordination to be strengthened vertically, i.e. between ministry and province, and between province and lower level SNAs in order to ensure all have clarity about roles and responsibilities. Very few respondents thought that the coordination should stay with FCF|REACT or an external body. There were suggestions that an independent FCF Secretariat would be beneficial.

Coordination and communication mechanisms: There were mixed views about what is happening currently in coordination and communication methods. While a majority felt that on the whole current procedures are sufficient, others cited very practical problems at local level. A number of reasons were given to explain concerns, for example, staff (primarily in the SNAs) lacking understanding of systems, insufficient staff, SCI needing to follow EU and USAID budget requirements which means some rules are different to those of the RGC, and/or the different approaches to budget matters between UNICEF and SCI. Even among those who thought that the mechanisms were sufficient there were comments such as information sharing could be improved. It was noted that some initiatives to share responsibilities between partners, for example having NGO partners lead on network learning activities, did not gain traction and so the lead remains with SCI, who would like to see others stepping up more. One respondent felt that when the provincial TWGs were fully operational coordination would improve and could help to work through the complications arising from the new decentralised SNA arrangements, with district level as the hub for service provision.

Future commitments: The DoSVY, WCCC, and CCWC respondents all understand this work is inherent in their mandate and committed to continuation, and gave examples of what they expect to be doing. WCCC respondents discussed budget allocation and trying to get resources from other sources and some CCWC respondents noted that they can advocate to get FCF activities into commune budgets. This is important given that many cite the lack of resources as the reason behind a number of current challenges. NGO respondents all expressed their willingness to continue supporting the work according to their different missions and available resources. Some noted that this work was a core component of their mission, while others stated that what they do in future would be dependent on other projects. The donors did not feel able to make commitments at this stage. UNICEF is different as they do not have REACT funding, but are supported by USAID for other activities. They hope and expect to continue their support beyond the current phase if new funding comes into place.

Resources: Most DoSVY, WCCC and CCWC respondents felt they have enough people in place to continue the work as expected, but some said they need more. However, many mentioned the need for capacity development to improve technical knowledge and skills of the staff. All NGO partners noted their expectation and intention to contribute human and technical resources in various ways, e.g. working to transfer knowledge of issues to CCWCs. Some will integrate FCF|REACT project activities under other budgets or are negotiating with donors to be able to do so. A few NGOs noted that they have the resources to continue specific aspects of the work, for example support for foster care. However, the majority noted that while they have sufficient staff in place they would need to raise funds from donors in order to be able to continue the work.

Knowledge and skills: On the subject of significant gaps in the knowledge and skills necessary to continue the work all groups had lists of issues need attention, including: social work skills and knowledge of transfers and reintegration for implementers; communication skills to work with communities; skills to train on positive parenting, the development of life skills and income generation; understanding the CCWC roles and responsibilities; ability to work with case management and data collection systems: and, improved skills for coordination and communications. None of which are new because they have been identified in previous assessment and planning processes. All acknowledged that there have been and will continue to be many activities to address the needs. When asked how the sector can continue to learn so that it remains technically up to date and is able to be flexible if circumstances change the respondents had a wide range of ideas, some of which are already in place, others of which are worthy of consideration.

Moving ahead: Opportunities: The respondents were all positive about the end of the FCF|REACT funding providing opportunities for the various groups involved in the work. While many felt it would be necessary to find new donors and partners to continue supporting activities, others felt this would be a good time to start negotiating with MEF for more allocation from the national budget and with other ministries for more synergy about child care and protection issues. Respondents in all groups expressed interest in coming together to reflect, learn from and document the experiences of this project not only to identify the best way forward, but also to share learning and possibly replicate the model. Several respondents, including in the SNAs, felt that this would be a good opportunity for MoSVY to take more leadership going forward. While they would want to continue collaboration with the current partners SNA respondents all noted that they would like responsibility for the work to be with them rather than NGOs.

Challenges for going forward and ways to overcome them: The respondents all had similar ideas about the challenges going forward, which included: the need for more funding to continue what is in place and expand to more provinces, some noted that MoSVY needs to have more ability to advocate for budget allocation from MEF; the need to improve the quality of both designated social workers and other officials involved in the work; the busyness, workload and capacity of SNA officials, especially at commune level; lack of technical capacity at higher levels of government to support the lower levels; most NGOs work on a short-term project basis; and, insufficient knowledge and resources for working with children with disabilities.

In terms of ways to overcome the challenges many respondents felt that it would be important for MoSVY to begin taking more leadership and a transition plan is needed, to set out how to hand over from NGOs to government, to reach consensus about roles and responsibilities and financial commitments. There was a suggestion for the RGC, development partners and NGOs to come together more to have open and honest discussions on where the sector is going, and this could perhaps be achieved in the TWG. Another very consistent theme in the respondents' suggestions was to continue capacity development for all actors, including the professional development of social workers.

Priority tasks for the next two years: The suggestions for priority tasks for the next two years are all focused on key aspects of the initiative and how it can go forward, namely enabling conditions, capacity development, resources, and planning.

> ***Enabling conditions***: the focus needs to be on the completion of all the outstanding legal instruments guidelines, and on strengthening coordination and communication mechanisms.

Capacity development: The main theme is to identify key stakeholders who will take the work forward and focus on their capacity development. Specific needs were noted as:

- *SNA*: make sure District and CCWC levels are fully knowledgeable and have the necessary technical skills, particularly on laws, administrative procedures and budgets
- *Social Service Workforce training curriculum*: finalisation and roll out try to get some level of accreditation for social workers in place

Resources: There were suggestions to develop two budgets that would enable MoSVY to negotiate with MEF for future resource allocation: a full costing of the systems for child support i.e. a defined minimum package of necessary services; and, a costed plan for the priority capacity development needs (see above). It was also noted that WCCC and CCWC need to know how to access existing SNA budgets for services and activities.

Planning: Several respondents emphasized the need to continue to implement existing plans. However, others also felt there would be value in reviewing the current strategy in order to decide what needs to be continued and what needs to be strengthened, and using this process to clarify roles and responsibilities and establish plans and mechanisms for more delegation to SNAs and communes in future.

In terms of responsibility for undertaking these priority tasks, respondents noted the work already being done in collaboration between MoSVY and the other key actors. There was consensus that MoSVY needs to take the lead on the issues that are relevant at the national level, such as finalizing legal instruments and working with other ministries. There were also expectations that different levels of SNA can step up to lead more on different needs, for example, DoSVY taking responsibility for roll out of *Prakas* and guidelines. Additionally, WCCC and CCWC need to lead on engaging with SNA processes for budget allocations at commune level. It is acknowledged that UNICEF and SCI are working closely with MoSVY on different components of capacity development.

Other issues for consideration: When asked if there was anything else important to add many respondents commented that they want the project to continue beyond the current phase and their hopes for the donors to continue their support. Most other comments were about issues that have already been covered in other sections. The only additional issue raised was the need for greater harmonisation between some of the key agencies supporting MoSVY and the sector.

Recommendations for the Sustainability Strategy

While much has been achieved so far in the first phase of FCF|REACT activities, and more will certainly be achieved in the final two years of FCF funding support, it is not realistic to expect that one project cycle is long enough to achieve sustainable change in such a complex system. This is especially the case given the hope of rolling out the approach beyond the initial five pilot provinces. The recommendations for this Sustainability Strategy are, therefore, proposed for the perspective of short- and medium-term measures to ensure the whole sector is permanently equipped to function effectively. Many of the activities already planned for the next two years will contribute significantly to sustainability, but to fully achieve the desired results many will also need to continue beyond this phase. Viewing the activities already planned for the next two years through a sustainability lens would help everyone to get a stronger perspective on longer term needs and how to meet them. That might in fact lead to some changes in how these planned activities are approached.

a) Design a transition phase follow on project

All key actors should work together, with appropriate consultation with the broader network, to **design the next phase of the initiative**. This will need to be conceptualised differently than the current project to emphasise a process of transitioning management, coordination and resourcing fully to MoSVY, while at the same time supporting service delivery to vulnerable children and families. The complexity of this

process requires the next phase to also be five years in duration. Transition to government leadership does not mean that there would not be a role for other agencies in future, but those roles may need to be defined differently. One aspect of the process should be assessment of what coordination and communication needs will be in future and designing appropriate structure to meet those needs. The results framework for the new project should be formulated to include measuring progress, perhaps in the form of a dashboard, towards achieving long-term sustainability factors for the sector. Work on designing the next phase should start as soon as possible because it will take time for all parties to negotiate and agree on the way forward in principle, and then to design the details of a project and develop a proposal for securing funding support. However, good progress on design of a new phase will be dependent on completion of the tasks set out below in the recommendation to Develop a Resource Mobilisation Strategy.

b) Develop a Resource Mobilisation Strategy

A resource mobilisation strategy should not only address funding needs, but also the broader range of resources needed for any initiative to function and achieve its goals. This can include technical support, in-kind contributions, and partnerships that provide support for some aspects of the work. Resources are needed for two main spheres of work. Firstly, service delivery, and secondly continued system strengthening and capacity development of all relevant actors. The first step should therefore be to **conduct a detailed costing exercise for the provision of services and the necessary capacity development programme.** Taking a holistic view of what is needed to support vulnerable children and their families could identify links to other sectors that could open up opportunities for resource mobilisation from new sources. It is therefore recommended that the next step in the development of a Resource Mobilisation Strategy is to **conduct a broad mapping exercise to identify which agencies have relevant resources to offer, both within the current network of partners, and beyond**. While this exercise should be mostly future-focused it will be important to realise any current funding opportunities that are not yet fully utilised, in particular, as noted by some of the WCCC and CCWC respondents, the annual CIP budget. Implementers struggling with resource availability could potentially be helped if they knew how to apply for money in this budget allocation.

c) Complete the development and roll out of laws, policies, Prakas, and guidelines

These processes are already in progress and/or are planned. Having **the legal framework and all the supporting guidelines for implementation fully in place** is an essential foundation for sector sustainability. Once the relevant documentation, tools and procedures are available there needs to be a comprehensive capacity development process to ensure that all relevant actors understand and know how to apply the laws and can complete all the necessary processes efficiently. This links closely to the capacity development recommendation below.

d) Continue existing capacity development initiatives

Capacity development activities are currently focused on two main areas of need – system strengthening and the knowledge and skills of implementers. Implementation of current plans, and planning for the future should address the following:

- System strengthening:
    - bringing into place all necessary enabling conditions, legal instruments and guidelines for application
    - coordination and communication mechanisms – including the TWGs at national and provincial levels,
    - case management and data recording systems
    - monitoring, evaluation and reporting systems
- Knowledge and skills of implementers:
    - Social Service Workforce training curriculum and roll out

- accreditation, supervision and ongoing professional development systems
- SNA personnel technical knowledge of laws, guidelines and procedures, including IT skills to work with digital systems
- SNA personnel knowledge of SNA budgets and how to access the 'social affairs' allocation to support FCF work in the communities
- SNA and NGO personnel knowledge and skills for working with vulnerable children and families, especially children with disabilities

Given the extent of the need both areas of **capacity development activity will have to continue for the foreseeable future.**

e) Embed full use of digital case management systems

There are now two case management and data recording systems in existence – PRIMERO and OSCaR. Apart from the case management and coordination benefits of having these systems fully inter-operable and in use they also offer the potential to produce evidence-based data that can be used in advocacy for negotiating resources. However, as yet, they are not fully implemented and it appears that few know how to work with them effectively, if at all, nor do the amount to a nationwide CPIMS. **Priority should therefore be given to full roll out of the systems, and to training those, especially in the SNAs, who need to use them.**

The inquiry process conducted to inform this strategy development exercise has shown that there is strong commitment across all the groups of stakeholders to take the work forward beyond the life of the current project. This commitment is a great asset that can be leveraged constructively to create solutions for the challenges of moving ahead to make the approach sustainable, and to extend it to new provinces so that eventually it becomes a nationwide system.

Implementation of the recommendations set out in this draft strategy, and adopting a sustainability lens for all future planning and implementation, will ensure that the necessary components for an effective and responsive child support sector will become embedded in all systems and practices and eventually lead to a permanently sustainable sector.

2. Introduction and background

FCF | REACT[1] is a network of organisations working together with the Royal Government of Cambodia (RGC), primarily the Ministry of Social Affairs, Veterans and Youth Rehabilitation (MoSVY) to support children to live in safe, nurturing family-based care. The network works collaboratively across the RGC and multiple agencies including local and international non-governmental organisations (NGOs), United Nations (UN) agencies, donors and academic institutions to promote and strengthen family-based care. Overall coordination is undertaken by the Lead Partner (LP) Save the Children International (SCI), working in close cooperation with three Implementing Partners (IPs), 13 other funded partners and approximately 45 unfunded network members. The aim of the work is to prevent children from being separated from their families and to increase the number of children that are safely and successfully reintegrated into family-based care if circumstances have led to them being separated. The approach taken by FCF|REACT is twofold, firstly to strengthen systems and policies, and secondly, direct provision of services to children and families. The project focuses specifically on four key results areas:

- National government is supported to roll out child protection legislative and policy frameworks with monitoring systems;
- Sub-national government authorities in five target provinces are supported to effectively monitor and regulate the quality of protection services and residential care institutions;
- Girls and boys who have been deprived of parental care and/or separated from their families are provided with appropriate quality alternative care and/or reintegration; and,
- Effective measures to prevent family separation are utilized in five target provinces.

A results-oriented monitoring (ROM) exercise of the EU-funded REACT component of the initiative was conducted in the first half of 2021, in anticipation of the funding phase completion at the end of the year. One of the recommendations made in the ROM report was as follows:

> *To ensure an adequate handover of REACT results and highlight future tasks/responsibilities of relevant stakeholders (including LP and IPs), consider developing a sustainability strategy. The strategy should address the stakeholders' roles (recognizing the role of government in leading the processes) and the planning for follow-up interventions, e.g., roll out of training module, training for the social workforce, reintegration and prevention activities etc.*

Subsequently, in consultation with the relevant stakeholders, SCI developed the terms of reference (see Annex 1) and hired VBNK, a local capacity development NGO, to lead the formulation of a Sustainability Strategy through a participatory process of consulting a representative sample of all the key stakeholder groups involved in the FCF|REACT initiative.

A final point of introduction is to note that this study was conducted at a time when all involved had been working with the challenges created by the COVID-19 pandemic for almost two years. This was not a focus of the inquiries, so nothing specific about the pandemic or the challenges it created are addressed in this report. However, answers provided by respondents are informed by their experiences and learning over the last two years, and the adaptations they have, of necessity, needed to make. This positive responsiveness to challenges is, in itself, an important element of sustainability that should be nurtured.

[1] Family Care First - Responsive and Effective Child Welfare Systems Transformation

3. Methodology

3.1 Overview of methodology

The methodology for developing the Sustainability Strategy comprised the following:

- **Document review**: study of relevant background reports about the FCF|REACT project
- **Development of a sustainability tool and questionnaire**: drafts of the tool and questionnaire were developed, shared with key stakeholders and finalised after feedback. The questionnaire was translated into Khmer for use in the interviews (the questionnaire is given at Annex 2)
- **Key informant interviews (KII):** KII were conducted with the following respondents (see Annex 3 for full list of respondents)
    - 5 people from Departments of Social Affairs, Veterans and Youth Rehabilitation (DoSVY) – one from each participating province
    - 5 people from Women's and Children's Consultative Committees (WCCC) – one from each participating province
    - 10 people from Commune Committees for Women and Children (CCWC) – two from each participating province
    - 2 senior managers from the LP
    - Representatives of the three IP, Friends International (FI), Mith Samlanh (MS) and the Cambodian Children's Trust (CCT)
    - 1 person from each of the donors, EU and USAID
    - 1 person from UNICEF
    - 5 people from 3rd party partners – selected by VBNK from the full list of partners
    - 5 people from FCF partners – selected by VBNK from the full list of partners
- **Analysis and formulation of draft** strategy: The Sustainability Tool was used as the framework for developing the questionnaire, summarising the data gathered from respondents, and analysing the findings. The findings were used to formulate recommendations for the main components of the strategy, together with identification of who should lead on each of the main tasks.
- **Workshop**: following circulation of the draft strategy to key stakeholders there was a consultation workshop to get their feedback in order to finalise the strategy.

3.2 Limitations

The time available for the consulting contractor to conduct the study was very short, as it had to be completed before the end of the REACT funding phase at the end of December 2021. This created some pressures in terms of being able to arrange meetings with all the nominated respondents. Due to busyness it was not possible to interview key people at MoSVY before the development of the draft strategy. Their input was, therefore, given at the workshop before the strategy was finalised.

4. The Sustainability Tool

Sustainability of any initiative, entity or set of conditions depends in the first instance on two key factors which can be described simply as demand and supply. The demand side calls for recognition among the stakeholders that there will continue to be need in future for what is currently in place, and that benefits will arise from ensuring that changes that have come into place continue in either the same or strengthened form. In general, if an initiative has been successful in addressing an important need it is relatively easy to reach agreement about the benefits of maintaining the changes, and in such cases the demand side of sustainability is assured.

The supply side of sustainability is the contribution needed from the different stakeholder groups to ensure that what is in place will stay in place and be maintained in ways that are fit for purpose. The supply side can be more difficult to agree, often because stakeholders are unclear about how they can proceed without the support of donor funding. However, sustainability is dependent on much more than

funding, and it is important that any strategy addresses not only the issue of financial resources, but all the dimensions needed to ensure success.

The components of sustainability for the sphere of work undertaken in the FCF|REACT project can be considered under three main headings, namely enabling conditions, resources, and, knowledge and skills. The sub-components of each are as follows:

- ***Enabling conditions:*** Laws, *Prakas*, guidelines, etc., vision and leadership, structure, communication and cooperation mechanisms, ownership and commitment. This group of components is important for ensuring that all the necessary conditions are in place for the approach to function effectively. Enabling conditions are now recognised as an essential dimension of the capacity needed for any entity or initiative to be able to fulfil its mandate.

- ***Resources:*** Human, financial and technical. This group of components is about the stakeholders having what they need to continue getting the necessary work tasks done for the initiative to continue functioning.

- ***Knowledge and skills:*** Networking and facilitation (including communication), technical and learning. This group of components is necessary to ensure that the initiative remains technically competent, learns from the experiences of implementation, and can respond appropriately and flexibly to any changes in circumstances.

The Sustainability Matrix at Annex 4 shows the framework used to explore and analyse the issues relevant for the results that have been achieved already and those yet to be achieved as a result of the FCF|REACT project.

5. Findings

5.1 Respondents' views on what is essential and desirable to continue

All respondent groups were unanimous that it is essential to continue the direct service provision to vulnerable children and families. Some were more specific than others in what this entailed, for example not only reintegration but also continuing monitoring and support to ensure placements do not break down so the children do not need to return to residential care institutes (RCIs). Several respondents also placed emphasis on preventative work. Linked issues were the need to ensure standards in the RCIs for cases for which there is no alternative, and also the need for skills building for families - positive parenting, income generation, and so on.

Beyond the core work of child care the respondents identified a number of themes of work that they consider it was essential to continue, as follows:

- Capacity development for strengthening all the relevant cooperation, coordination and monitoring mechanisms (system strengthening), especially at the sub-national level
- Capacity development for both government and NGOs involved in the work, with a special focus on officials at sub-national level who have new roles and responsibilities for work with children
- The completion and roll out of the Social Service Workforce training curriculum
- Mechanisms and processes, such as technical working groups (TWGs) to provide technical support both for the Ministry and at implementation level
- The provision of resources to do the work, including diversification of funding sources and the ability of all relevant stakeholders to mobilise resources from appropriate sources

- The development and implementation of inter-operable digital case management systems – OSCaR and PRIMERO[2], leading to a nationwide Child Protection Information Management System (CPIMS)
- Documentation and dissemination of best practice
- Work on the child protection sector plan priorities
- Development of a transition plan for RGC to take over eventually, including lobbying the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) for resource allocation
- Coordination network learning and sharing, especially including smaller provincial based organisations]
- Finalising various plans, including provincial child protection plans, and putting existing plans fully into operation

Several respondents noted the importance of partnership between MoSVY and all other ministries and agencies involved as the means to ensure that the relevant elements of support continue to be available for the sector, and relevant support is leveraged from other systems such as health and education.

Additionally, respondents noted that, if possible, it would be desirable to continue or start the following aspects of the current initiative:

- Learning opportunities such as exchange visits and development of a knowledge sharing working group
- Technical support for implementers to be involved in programme development
- Moving away from international NGOs towards more local NGOs doing implementation and also leading on capacity development, more emphasis on peer learning than bringing in international experts
- Giving greater focus to special needs groups such as children with disabilities, or people living with HIV/AIDS, including provision of legal services for vulnerable children or those in conflict with the law
- Counselling services for vulnerable children
- Strengthening foster care provisions
- Research studies (subjects not specified)
- Financial input for the coordination of technical meetings
- Capacity development of RCI managers to have greater focus on preparing children for reintegration into communities

5.2 Enabling conditions

5.2.1 Legal framework

A critically important element of enabling conditions is having in place all the necessary laws, *Prakas,* policies, and guidelines to mandate and guide the work. These instruments can also be helpful in providing frameworks for the mobilisation and distribution of resources. The respondents were all clear that, with the exception of the Law on National Adoption and Law on Child Protection, the legal framework is in place. However, the respondents were unanimous in their view that while the legal framework exists, there is much to be done in terms of implementing and operationalising the different legal instruments. Many noted that tools and systems have yet to be finalised, adopted and rolled out, and this in turn means that many of the implementers still have limited or no awareness and understanding of their roles, responsibilities and tasks. It was noted that this is particularly the case for those with implementation responsibilities at WCCC, district and commune level. Some DoSVY

[2] PRIMERO, which is an open source software platform, is the MoSVY case management system to be used nationwide. UNICEF supported the development and implementation of PRIMERO. MoSVY also has in place a Child Protection Information Management System. However, neither of these systems constitute a national data base. The NGOs in the network are using OSCaR (Open Source Case Management and Record Keeping) the implementation of which was supported by USAID.

respondents expressed concern about whether or not they are implementing properly because they did not feel they had sufficient depth of understanding about all the laws, *Prakas* and guidelines governing this area of their responsibilities. This need is linked to the recent restructuring of how local authorities operate as part of the national decentralization programme, which is another example of the need for inter-ministry cooperation because the Ministry of Interior (MoI) is responsible for the functioning, including budget allocation, of the sub-national authorities (SNAs). The majority of commune level respondents could only state that they know laws and guidelines exist, but not what they are.

A theme that came up in response to this question and frequently in response to others is the need for **a** system of accredited and supervised social work practice, which should start with job descriptions for ministry salaried social workers.

A number of respondents noted specific gaps and needs as follows:

- For guidance about risk management and adaption in times of natural disaster, as highlighted by the COVID-19 pandemic
- For greater inter-ministry understanding and collaboration about issues that cross sectors, such as work with children with disabilities
- A new action plan for the sector
- Because guidelines for implementation are not yet in place, there is no clear basis for monitoring and evaluation which is an important gap in terms of oversight and accountability

The NGO respondents were also concerned with the need for a unified case management system, including for transfers, and for guidelines for family-based care.

In conclusion about the legal framework, it should be noted that there are several processes currently underway to develop, finalise, formally adopt and roll out the necessary laws and guidelines.

5.2.2 Vision and leadership

When asked about their vision for the future of supporting family-based care work in Cambodia and who should be leading the sector the respondents were again unanimous in their view that MoSVY should be leading, both at national and sub-national levels. Respondents saw that this work is primarily the responsibility of MoSVY, but some also noted the need for collaboration with other ministries, especially MoI. Many also saw the need for NGOs to continue having a role both in supporting government and for direct implementation. Several respondents noted that government being able to take on full leadership was dependent both on resources (funding) availability and the capacity of relevant government staff. It was, additionally, noted that this necessary funding and capacity is not going to come into place by the end of this project, so it is not realistic to expect MoSVY to take on full responsibility for all aspects of the work within the time frame of this project. There needs to be a carefully negotiated and planned process of incremental transition as funding and capacity come into place, which should, eventually, also enable MoSVY and supporting agencies such as UNICEF the key NGOs to agree any changes in how they work together in future.

Suggestions for how this transition process can be supported included: focusing on coordination at district level under the decentralization master plan; enhancing the role of the child protection TWG; strengthening MoSVY advocacy to the MEF for budget allocation; and local advocacy for budget allocation in the annual Commune Investment Plan (CIP) process.

5.2.3 Coordination structure

In general respondents felt that current coordination structures work well. Consideration of future needs was addressed at different levels. Some respondents focused on the national level, noting that MoSVY should lead through mechanisms such as the TWG with a high level chairperson. Others added that relevant UN agencies and NGOs should also be involved. Likewise at SNA level all thought it should be government led, but some also mentioned the need for UN and NGO support, including the provision of financial support.

Several respondents focused on the importance of the provincial level and having provincial TWGs in order to ensure good coordination, and that this need again links to MoI processes and procedures for the decentralised SNA. They noted the complexity of the sector and focused on provincial level coordination due to the frequent need to cooperate with the police, health and education officials, and the Department of Women's Affairs.

There were some comments about the need for coordination to be strengthened vertically, i.e. between ministry and province, and between province, district and commune in order to ensure all have clarity about roles and responsibilities.

Very few respondents thought that the coordination should stay with FCF|REACT or an external body. There were suggestions that it would be beneficial if the structure was more independent of key actors, for example an FCF Secretariat responsible only to a governing body such as an Advisory Board or sector TWG.

5.2.4 Coordination and communication mechanisms

There were mixed views about what is happening currently in coordination and communication methods. While a majority felt that on the whole current procedures are sufficient, others cited very practical problems at local level. A number of reasons were given to explain concerns, for example, staff (primarily in the SNAs) lacking understanding of systems, insufficient staff, SCI needing to comply with EU and USAID budget requirements which means some rules are different to those of the RGC, and/or the different approaches to budget matters between UNICEF and SCI. Even among those who thought that the mechanisms were sufficient there were comments, such as information sharing could be improved. Some respondents expressed concerns that the current system is too dependent on donor funding, which raises questions about what will happen when the project ends. It was noted that some initiatives to share responsibilities between partners, for example having NGO partners taking the lead on different network learning activities, did not gain traction and so the lead remains with SCI, who would like to see others stepping up more. One respondent felt that coordination would improve when the provincial TWGs were fully operational and this could help to work through the complications arising from the new decentralised SNA arrangements, with district level as the hub for service provision.

5.2.5 Future commitments

The DoSVY, WCCC and CCWC respondents all committed to continuing the work, because they understand it is inherent in their mandate. Several gave practical examples of what they expect to be doing in future. Importantly, some CCWC respondents noted that they can advocate to get FCF activities into commune budgets. Likewise, WCCC respondents discussed budget allocation and trying to get resources from other sources like the Cambodian Red Cross. This is important given that many cite the lack of resources as the reason behind a number of current challenges.

NGO respondents all expressed their willingness to continue to support the work according to their different missions and available resources. Some noted that this work was a core component of their programme, while others stated that what they could do in future would be dependent on other projects.

Some felt they could offer technical support if and when needed, regardless of having specific funding support. (See section 5.3 below for more on resources). One of the IPs has an interesting initiative over next two years to develop a model approach to integrated services, including child care and protection, with plans to scale up to 10 communes. They are seeking to create an community focused, evidence-based approach that can be replicated.

The donors did not feel able to commit to anything at this stage. UNICEF is in a somewhat different position as they do not have REACT funding but are supported by other USAID funding for other activities. They hope and expect to continue their support beyond the current phase if new funding comes into place.

5.3 Resources

When asked about resource availability to continue the work DoSVY respondents had mixed answers. Most said they have enough human resources in place to continue the work as expected, but one said they need more people. Two commented that they need capacity development to update technical capacity, particularly of WCCC and CCWC. WCCC respondents all commented that they will be able to provide human resources, but two said they don't yet have enough people to do all the work. Most CCWC respondents noted that there are sufficient human resources and the commune does have some budget for the work.

All of these respondents said they need more resources and, appropriately, they expected to get budget support from central government, but several also mentioned NGOs as a source of funding. Two DoSVY respondents requested capacity development for social workers and technical expertise. Several WCCC and CCWC respondents noted the need for ongoing capacity development for the relevant personnel. An important point noted by a CCWC respondent is that 30% of CIP budgets[3] can be allocated to '*social welfare development*'.

All NGO partners noted their expectation and intention to contribute human and technical resources in various ways, e.g. working to transfer to CCWCs knowledge of issues and how to respond. Some aim to integrate FCF|REACT project activities under other budgets or are negotiating with donors to be able to do so. Several noted being able to provide technical support to others when needed, and they would want to continue their involvement in various working groups. A few of the NGOs noted that they have the resources to continue specific aspects of the work, for example support for foster care. However, the majority said that while they have sufficient staff in place to continue the work doing so would depend on raising funds from donors.

As noted above donors do not feel able to comment on any future resource commitments at this stage. UNICEF expects that they will be able to provide some financial and technical support.

5.4 Knowledge and skills

[3] The structure of CIP annual budgets requires the allocated money to be spread across four components: social affairs, the local economy, the environment, and administration and security. Unspent money in one component cannot be allocated to another. It appears that often the social affairs component of a CIP remains unspent because the local planners and decision makers do not understand the issues well and therefore do not know how to formulate relevant activities and initiatives, as opposed, for example, to infrastructure projects which will produce very visible results.

On the subject of significant gaps in the knowledge and skills necessary to continue the work the CCWC respondents said that from their perspective many issues need attention, for example:

- Attitudes/knowledge of families about how to care for their children, and skills and resources to facilitate awareness raising in communities about issue like child labour
- Transfer and reintegration skills for implementers
- Ability to complete the paperwork
- Communication skills to work with communities
- Proposal development and resource mobilization
- Understanding the CCWC roles and responsibilities

Notably some of these are generic skills and not specific to FCF|REACT activities but they are nonetheless important.

DoSVY respondents noted the need for all concerned to understand and be able to work with the digital case management systems, which they consider to be essential for efficient and effective provision of services to the children. They also thought that everyone needed more knowledge of the legal frameworks.

The list from WCCC respondents was:

- Social work skills for the implementers
- Skills to train on positive parenting, the development of life skills and income generation
- Better ability to collect data, e.g. on children with disabilities
- State officials to have ability to formulate projects and proposals for social service delivery

The other respondent groups raised a wide range of issues which they felt needed to be addressed, some being about knowledge and skills, while others were about attitudes and approaches:

- Government ownership of FCF|REACT needs to be strengthened because there are both national and local level perceptions that the initiative belongs to NGOs. It was noted that this does need resources, and currently too much is based on donors and NGOs leading initiatives.
- Social worker expertise based on thorough professional training, which is linked to the need for a certification system to recognize those who are qualified.
- Related to all involved in implementation generally - their knowledge of social work for child care and protection issues, such as sexual abuse, is limited and they need a lot of capacity development
- Improved skills for coordination and communications
- Ability to work with the case management and data collection systems – OSCaR and PRIMERO – including information technology (IT) skills as some are still using paper systems
- Understanding of policies on transfers, reintegration and closing the RCIs
- How to work in ways that emphasise prevention rather than crisis responses

One of the donors noted that this context is no different from any other in the sense that knowledge and skills always need to be upgraded in response to changes in context, and so there will always be gaps that need to be addressed. Additionally, there is an ongoing need after elections and other change processes to ensure that incoming councillors and committee members have the knowledge they need to fulfil their mandate.

UNICEF explained the process they are working on with MoSVY to roll out implementation of a large capacity development plan for the Social Service Workforce[4]. This is a very big undertaking, designed

[4] FCF | REACT worked with MoSVY and partners to support the development of the guidelines on basic competency for the Social Service Workforce, which were adopted in late 2019. FCF | REACT, in collaboration with UNICEF, now support MoSVY on the development of the draft training curriculum and training modules based on the guidelines addressing four levels of Social Service Workforce, namely Level 1 - commune, Level 2 – district, Level 3 – provincial, and Level 4 – national. FCF | REACT is responsible for 28 of the 80 training modules, already completed and it is anticipated that all modules to be completed by 2022. The training roll out is expected to start mid 2022. The training will be

to address the significant gap in the number and expertise of social workers in government structures. The plan includes eventually putting an accreditation scheme in place. The initiative is partly funded, and UNICEF needs to work with MoSVY, MoI and others to source full support.

When asked how the sector can continue to learn so that it remains technically up to date and is able to be flexible if circumstances change the respondents had a wide range of ideas. At the implementing level of CCWC and some of the NGOs the focus was very much on continuing to be involved in capacity development activities provided by others, citing multiple needs such as IT skills, knowledge of the law, and positive parenting. WCCC respondents were all concerned with basic capacity development needs for different stakeholder groups like parents and implementers.

Other respondents had some interesting ideas about what they thought would enhance sector learning, as follows (not in order of importance):

- More use of IT for sharing knowledge and resources, and for access to digital resources
- Identification and sharing of best practice, not only in Cambodia but also from other countries. Explore possibilities offered by ASEAN and other international fora
- Continue capacity development for the Social Service Workforce and establish a process for continuous professional development, including how to gain and maintain accreditation
- Develop, finance and implement a comprehensive capacity development strategy for improving the understanding of SNA officials who are in some way concerned with the work, but are not designated members of the Social Service Workforce
- Use of the PRIMERO data management system to gain understanding about the effectiveness of the programmes and approaches in use
- Evaluate and reflect on experiences of the work in order to learn through from practice
- Take a holistic approach, linked to system strengthening and including making the profession attractive so it gets the best people
- Strengthen the TWG, communities of practice and peer mentoring to support learning. Map out what expertise different NGOs have and can contribute to help others learn
- Establish a central facility to connect people with the resources for their learning needs
- Review policy to see if it still fits to context
- Continually observe and listen to understand changes in context and circumstances, then adapt to changing needs (similar to a community development approach)
- Research studies, led and facilitated by network members (no specific research topics were mentioned)

5.5 Moving ahead: priorities for the remainder of the FCF funding period

5.5.1 Opportunities

The respondents were all positive about the end of the FCF funding providing opportunities for the various groups involved in the work. While many felt it would be necessary to find new donors and partners to continue supporting activities, others felt this would be a good time to start negotiating with MEF for more allocation from the national budget. In this regard there was a suggestion about conducting a mapping exercise to identify sources of both financial and other resources that are available, both in this sector and others, that could be accessed to support the work. There were also suggestions about this being a good opportunity for MoSVY to engage further with other relevant ministries.

Respondents in all groups expressed interest in coming together to reflect, learn from and document the experiences of this project, not only to identify the best way forward but also to share learning and possibly replicate the model. As one respondent noted, this opportunity to design a new project, based

conducted through close collaboration between MoSVY and MoI, supported by key partners including UNICEF and SCI (FCF | REACT).

on what has been achieved, provides the opportunity to look at what is in place and identify real value add for future development of the sector. This should include ways of strengthening coordination and partnerships, because the sector will always need multi-agency collaboration. Others stressed the need, in future, to work more with communities on prevention strategies, and that this should be a key feature of any new project design.

Several respondents, including in the SNAs, felt that this would be a good opportunity for MoSVY to take more leadership going forward. While they would want to continue collaboration with the current partners DoSVY, WCCC and CCWC respondents all noted that they would like responsibility for the work to be with them rather than NGOs.

Other points made were that given all that has been achieved on reintegration the end of the project presents a good opportunity to shift the focus to prevention, and that making more use of online technology would provide stronger support for the work.

5.5.2 Challenges for going forward and ways to overcome them

The respondents all had similar ideas about the challenges going forward, which they identified as:

- The need for more funding to continue what is in place and expand to more provinces, some noted that MoSVY needs to have more ability to advocate for budget allocation from MEF
- The low level of understanding and skills within some SNAs about budgeting and financial management
- The need to improve the quality of Social Service Workforce, both designated social workers and other officials involved in the work
- The busyness, workload and capacity of SNA officials, especially at commune level. Many are overwhelmed by their responsibilities and need a lot of capacity development and support
- How to maintain systematic coordination among the different actors, especially at sub-national levels, because it is not yet strong enough
- Lack of technical capacity at higher levels of government to support the lower levels
- The fact that most NGOs work on a short-term project basis and their support to beneficiaries might cease when their projects end.
- Many small local NGOs involved in the work still need a lot of strengthening
- Child protection is not a priority with most donors, they mostly support tertiary level services
- Insufficient knowledge and resources for working with children with disabilities

In terms of ways to overcome the challenges many respondents felt that it would be important for MoSVY to begin taking more leadership, and that process should start with SCI and UNICEF stepping back in order to create the space for MoSVY to lead on issues such as advocacy and coordination. One respondent suggested that the RGC, development partners and NGOs need to come together more to have open and honest discussions on where the sector is going, and this could perhaps be achieved in the national level TWG. One respondent said that a transition plan was needed, to set out how to hand over from NGOs to government, to reach consensus about roles and responsibilities and financial commitments.

Another very consistent theme in the respondents' suggestions was to continue capacity development for all actors, including the professional development of the Social Service Workforce. Several noted that this is a long-term issue that cannot be resolved quickly. There was a suggestion to look at what might be available through links within ASEAN that could be leveraged to help develop the sector. Another suggestion was to recruit more skilled social workers now, especially those with expertise in working with children with disabilities. Similarly, many respondents noted the need to strengthen

cooperation and communication between MoSVY and all other actors. DoSVY and CCWC mentioned seeking support from new NGO partners, and in turn the NGOs mentioned seeking alternative funding sources. One NGO thought it would be useful to look at sub-national budget allocation to see if some could be allocated for this area of work. There was also a suggestion to explore what the private sector might be able to offer.

5.5.3 Priority tasks for the next two years

The suggestions for priority tasks for the next two years are all focused on key aspects of the initiative and how it can go forward, namely enabling conditions, capacity development, resources, and planning.

Enabling conditions: focus on two main issues. Firstly, the completion of all the outstanding laws, *Prakas,* policies and guidelines. Secondly, strengthen existing coordination and communication mechanisms. Some respondents noted the need to begin handover of case management from NGOs to state actors through the use of the digital systems, in order to develop fully the nationwide CPIMS so that it can be used for multiple purposes, including monitoring the effectiveness of approaches and activities, and advocacy for resources.

Capacity development: The main theme suggested is identification of key stakeholders who will take the work forward and focus on their capacity development. Specific needs were noted as:

- *SNA development*: make sure District and CCWC levels are fully knowledgeable and have the necessary technical skills, particularly on laws, administrative procedures and budgets
- *Social Service Workforce training curriculum*: finalisation and roll out of the training programme to get qualified social workers in place

Resources: There were suggestions to develop two budgets that would enable MoSVY to negotiate with MEF, and others, for future resource allocation. The first should be a costing of the systems for child support i.e. a defined minimum package of necessary services, and the second should be costed plan for the priority capacity development needs (see above). It was also noted that WCCC and CCWC need to know how to access existing MoI budget allocations to SNAs to support services and activities.

Other suggestions were made about the need to start seeking funding from other sources including new partners, in order to reduce the current level of dependence on FCF|REACT as the funding source.

Planning: Several respondents emphasized the need to continue to implement existing plans, especially the work at sub-national level on the Child Protection Plan and completion of the remaining RCI transfers. However, others also felt there would be value in MoSVY and key actors reviewing the current strategy in order to decide what needs to be continued and what, if anything, needs to be strengthened. This process could also be useful for clarifying roles and responsibilities and establishing plans and mechanisms for more delegation to SNAs and communes in future.

One respondent also suggested that it would be beneficial to create a shared vision among all actors to enhance their commitment to sustainability.

In terms of responsibility for undertaking these priority tasks, the respondents noted that much work is already being done in collaboration between MoSVY and the other actors in the sector and network. There was consensus that MoSVY needs to take the lead on the issues that are relevant at the national level, such as finalizing legal instruments and working with other ministries, and many respondents noted what is already happening, with different types of support being provided as needed by other agencies such as UNICEF and SCI. It was also noted that the TWG can be helpful for bringing together the data needed for budget allocation.

It is acknowledged that UNICEF are working closely with MoSVY on the Social Service Workforce training programme, and most respondents expect SCI to take the lead on capacity development for

other implementation level needs. But there were also expectations that different levels of SNA can step up to lead more on different needs, for example, DoSVY taking responsibility for roll out of *Prakas* and guidelines. Additionally, WCCC and CCWC need to lead on engaging with SNA processes for budget allocations at commune level.

5.5.4 Other issues for consideration

When asked if there was anything else important to add many respondents commented that they want the project to continue beyond the current phase and shared their hopes for the donors to continue their support. Most other comments were about issues that have already been covered in the sections above. The only additional issue raised was the need for greater harmonisation between some of the key agencies supporting MoSVY and the sector, in part to simplify rules and procedures, and in part to provide a better model of what is needed across the whole sector between MoSVY and all other agencies.

6 Recommendations for the Sustainability Strategy

6.1 Overview of the approach to sustainability

The FCF|REACT initiative has been addressing the need for change in the child welfare system. It has involved multiple stakeholders at all levels of government, working alongside UN agencies, multiple international and local NGOs, communities and families. It has worked to resolve not only the immediate needs of vulnerable children and families, but also all of the related capacity necessary to have in place for effective child welfare support to take place. This starts with enabling conditions such as the necessary laws, policies, strategies and guidelines, and having the right resources available to support activities including important systems such as case management. Very importantly, the initiative has paid considerable attention to capacity development of all groups of stakeholders, working to bring into place the knowledge and expertise needed to ensure that vulnerable children are protected and supported in situations other than RCIs, ideally with their own families, but in other suitable arrangements when that is not possible. When considered together these factors amount to a very complex system.

While much has been achieved so far in the first phase of FCF|REACT activities, and more will certainly be achieved in the final two years of FCF funding support, it is not realistic to expect sustainable change will come into place in such a complex system in the life of one project cycle. This is especially the case given the hope of rolling out the approach beyond the initial five pilot provinces. The recommendations for this Sustainability Strategy are, therefore, proposed for the perspective of ensuring the whole sector is equipped to function effectively in the long term.

Many of the activities already planned for the next two years will contribute significantly to sustainability, but to fully achieve the desired objectives many will also need to continue beyond this phase. For example, getting in place the full complement of qualified and accredited social workers that the RGC decides are needed within its various structures will start with the training that is already planned, but that programme will take more than two years to complete. Additionally, once Social Service Workforce are trained and functioning in their designated positions, appropriate supervision systems (and the related expertise) will also need to be put in place, along with processes for continuous professional development. On the other hand, activities such as the development of guidelines should be completed within this project phase and will not need to continue, although it will be important to ensure regular

review and updating as required in future years, refresher courses as needed, and also orientation for new personnel in various positions.

The recommendations begin with planning for another project phase. This should not be thought of in terms of a simple continuation of what is already happening, but as a transition phase in which all actors work together in incremental steps towards MoSVY taking over full leadership of and responsibility for management, coordination and resources of the child care sector. The plan for a new phase would likely not need to introduce many new areas of activity, but should emphasise the priorities for creating strong foundations for moving closer to permanent sustainability of the sector's ability to function effectively.

Viewing the activities already planned for the next two years through a sustainability lens could help everyone to get a stronger perspective on longer term needs and what is needed to fulfil them. That might in fact lead to some changes in how these planned activities are approached.

6.2 Recommendations

a) Design a transition phase follow on project

All key actors – MoSVY, UNICEF, the LP and IPs – should work together, with appropriate consultation with the broader network, to **design the next phase of the initiative**. This will need to be conceptualised differently than the current project with the emphasis on a process of transitioning management, coordination and resourcing fully to MoSVY, while, of course, at the same time supporting service delivery to vulnerable children and families. As this will be a complex process consideration should be given to the next phase also being five years in duration. Transition to government leadership should not be taken to mean that there would not be a role for other agencies in future, but their roles may need to be defined differently, by agreement among all the stakeholders as change emerges over time. One aspect of the process should be assessment of what coordination and communication needs will be in future and designing an appropriate structure or entity to meet those needs.

The results framework for the new project should be formulated to include measuring progress, perhaps in the form of a dashboard, towards achieving long-term sustainability factors for the sector.

Work on designing the next phase should start as soon as possible because it will take time for all parties to negotiate and agree on the way forward in principle, and then to design the details of a project and develop proposals for securing funding support. However, good progress on design of a new phase will be dependent on completion of the tasks set out below in the recommendation to Develop a Resource Mobilisation Strategy.

b) Develop a Resource Mobilisation Strategy

A resource mobilisation strategy should not only address funding needs, but also the broader range of resources needed for any initiative to function and achieve its goals. This can include technical support, in-kind contributions, and partnerships that provide support for some aspects of the work. Resources are needed for two main spheres of work: service delivery and continued system strengthening and capacity development of all relevant actors. The first step should therefore be to **conduct a detailed costing exercise for the provision of services and the necessary capacity development programme,** as discussed in section 5.5.3 Priority Task for the Next Two Years above. The aim should be to complete this exercise during 2022 as the information generated would be an important component of proposal development for next phase funding. This is also an essential step for MoSVY to be able to negotiate for budget allocation with MEF.

Taking a holistic view of what is needed to support vulnerable children and their families could potentially indicate links to other sectors, which in turn could open up opportunities for resource mobilisation from new sources. For example, the Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries, the Ministry of Women's Affairs, and the Ministry of Commerce all have, from time to time, programmes and projects that could be relevant for family income generation, or skills building for young people to enter the employment workforce. All of which could be very relevant to taking a more preventative approach by working with

communities to alleviate poverty. There is also value in looking at how to link more systematically with relevant resources that are already available in communities, especially in health and education, and how to leverage scare specialist resources such physiotherapy for children with disabilities. It is therefore recommended that the next step in the development of a Resource Mobilisation Strategy is to **conduct a broad mapping exercise to identify which agencies have relevant resources to offer, both within the current network of partners, and beyond**. The aim should be to complete this exercise during 2022 as the information generated would also be invaluable for proposal development for next phase funding.

Neither of the two main donors for FCF|REACT are currently in a position to state whether or not they will be able to support a future phase, in large part because such decisions are made in headquarters not in the in-country missions. This does not mean that there is no possibility of further support, only that it cannot be known at this time. In any circumstance it is always advisable to seek a diverse funding base, and this work is no exception. Some of the NGOs in the network depend on FCF|REACT funding to support service delivery, others are able to call on alternative sources of funding. While ultimately this should be the responsibility of the RGC, it is unlikely, for multiple reasons, that MoSVY will have the budget to provide that support in the foreseeable future.

While this exercise should be mostly future focused it will be important to realise any current untapped funding opportunities. In particular, a potentially important source of support, noted by some of the WCCC and CCWC respondents, is the annual CIP budget, as discussed above in Section 5.3. Additionally, each commune also has an annual Social Fund allocation. In many communes the social components of the budget are routinely unspent or underspent because the councils do not know what they should be spending it on, as opposed to, for example, infrastructure projects that help the local economy. Implementers struggling with resource availability could potentially be helped if they knew how to apply for money in this budget allocation. Knowledge of CIP budgets and how to access them should be addressed in capacity development initiatives for district and commune level personnel.

c) Complete the development and roll out of laws, Prakas, and guidelines

These processes are already in progress and/or are planned. Having **the legal framework and all the supporting guidelines for implementation fully in place** is an essential foundation for sector sustainability. Once the relevant documentation, tools and procedures are available there needs to be a comprehensive capacity development process to ensure that all relevant actors understand and know how to apply the laws and can complete all the necessary processes efficiently. This links closely to the capacity development recommendation below.

d) Continue existing capacity development initiatives

Capacity development activities are currently focused on two main areas of need – system strengthening, and the knowledge and skills of implementers. Given the extent of the need **capacity development will continue to be needed for both areas for the foreseeable future**. A key feature of capacity development initiatives needs to be developing internal capacity to provide this important component of the programme so that there is increasingly less dependence on bringing in international expertise. Implementation of current plans, and planning for the future should therefore address the following:

- System strengthening:
    - bringing into place all necessary enabling conditions, legal instruments and guidelines for application
    - coordination and communication mechanisms – including the TWGs at national and provincial levels
    - case management and data recording systems
    - monitoring, evaluation and reporting systems
- Knowledge and skills of implementers:
    - Social Services Workforce training curriculum and roll out,
    - accreditation, supervision and ongoing professional development systems

- SNA personnel technical knowledge of laws, *Prakas,* guidelines and procedures, including IT skills to work with digital systems
- SNA personnel knowledge of CIP budgets and how to access the 'social affairs' allocation to support FCF work in the communities
- SNA and NGO personnel knowledge and skills for working with vulnerable children and families, especially children with disabilities
- training of trainers for all above needs

e) Embed full use of digital case management systems

There are now two case management and data recording systems in existence - PRIMERO, MoSVY system and OSCaR, which is used by the NGO partners in the network. Apart from the case management and coordination benefits of having these systems fully inter-operable and in use they also offer the potential to produce evidence-based data that can be used in advocacy for negotiating resources. However, as yet, they are not fully implemented and it appears that few know how to work with them effectively, if at all. **Priority should therefore be given to full roll out of the systems, and to training those, especially in the SNAs, who need to use them**.

7 Conclusion

The inquiry process conducted to inform this strategy development exercise has shown that there is strong commitment across all the different groups of stakeholders to take the work forward beyond the life of the current project. This commitment is a great asset that can be leveraged constructively to create solutions for the challenges of moving ahead to make the approach sustainable, and to extend it to new provinces so that eventually it is a nationwide system.

Implementation of the recommendations set out in this strategy, and adopting a sustainability lens for all future planning and implementation, will ensure that the necessary components for an effective and responsive child support sector will become embedded in all systems and practices.

List of Annexes

1. Terms of Reference
2. Questionnaire for the Interviews
3. List of respondents
4. Sustainability matrix

Annex 1: Terms of Reference

Terms of Reference

FCF | REACT

Thematic name	Child Protection
Project name	REACT
Topic	Sustainability Strategy Development
Implementation team	FCF|REACT
Assignment Location	Phnom Penh, Kandal, Battambang, Siem Reap, SHV
Report to	Seang Meng, FCF|REACT Deputy Chief of Party
Assignment Period of Completion	October-November 2021

Save the Children (SC) is the world's largest independent child rights organization, working in more than 120 countries, including Cambodia. Save the Children in Cambodia implements its programmes in partnership with the Government, civil society and relevant research organizations. We work with communities, local NGO's and community-based organizations to deliver projects that help ensure children are protected, health and educated. We work with the Royal Government of Cambodia and civil society to ensure that our development efforts are sustainable. Save the Children in Cambodia work in the whole spectrum of child development through 5 programmes: Education, Child Protection, Child Rights Government, Health & Nutrition, and Child Poverty. Save the Children works in both development and emergency contexts, ensuring that cross-cutting areas such as gender, disability, resiliency, and remoteness are key considerations to achieve immediate and lasting change for the most marginalized and most disadvantaged.

I. Background:

FCF | REACT, facilitated by Save the Children, is a network of organizations working together to support children to live in safe, nurturing family-based care. We work collaboratively with the government, local and international NGOs, academic institutions and UN agencies, to promote and strengthen family-based care. With approximately 60-member organizations, some of whom are funded, we are working to prevent children from being separated from their families and increase the number of children that are safely and successfully integrated into family-based care. We do this by strengthening systems and policies and working directly to provide services to children and families through four key result areas:

- National government is supported to roll out child protection legislative and policy frameworks with monitoring systems.
- Sub-national government authorities in five target provinces are supported to effectively monitor and regulate the quality of protection services and residential care institutions.
- Girls and boys who have been deprived of parental care and/or separated from their families are provided with appropriate quality alternative care and/or reintegration.
- Effective measures to prevent family separation are utilized in five target provinces.

II. Objective

The objective of this consultancy is to develop a sustainability strategy to ensure an adequate handover of REACT results and highlight future tasks/responsibilities of relevant stakeholders (including LP and IPs). The strategy should address the stakeholders' roles (recognizing the role of government in leading

the processes) and the planning for follow-up interventions, e.g., roll out of training modules, training for the social workforce, reintegration and prevention activities etc.

The consultant will work in close collaboration with Save the Children and the FCF|REACT team to define the methodology for collecting and assessing the level of sustainable activities at national and sub-national level and based on these findings to recommend for sustainable strategy.

This documentation will be shared broadly with MoSVY, Sub-national government authorities in five target provinces, UNICEF, FCF | REACT Members, and other interested stakeholders.

III. Methodology

The FCF | REACT especially Deputy Chief of Party with support from MEAL team will oversee the overall direction of the consultancy.

The methodology, including sustainability assessment tool and interview/questionnaire guide will need to be designed by the consultant, in close collaboration with Save the Children and consult with MoSVY.

A workshop after the strategies drafted will be organized by involving all government stakeholders from 5 targeted provinces (Phnom Penh, Sihanuk Ville, Battambong, Kandal and Siem Reap) and implementing partners aimed to discuss and give feedback on the proposed way forward regarding to the recommended strategies.

The process of this study can be through the following methods:

- Desk study and review of all relevant project documentation including project documents, annual work-plans, project progress reports, annual project reports, reports of the project steering committee
- Develop and send out the program sustainability assessment tools in order to get inputs from FCF | REACT funded partners
- In depth interviews to gather primary data from key stakeholders (2 people from MoSVY, 5 people from DoSVY, 5 people from WCCC, 10 people from CCWC, 1 from FI, 1 from MS, 1 from CCT, 1 from UNICEF, 5 from selected 3rd party, 5 from selected FCF partners)

IV. Roles and Responsibilities

- Consultant
  1. Develop work plan, protocol and tools in consultation with Save the Children
  2. Be responsible for quality of work, with guidance from FCF|REACT Team
  3. Use their own equipment, support personnel, support services, and transportation needed for the consultancy work;
  4. Report progress of work on a weekly basis to FCF|REACT Deputy Chief of Party
  5. Perform data analysis
  6. Present first draft report to Save the Children in a timely manner
  7. Take into consideration Save the Children's input and review comments
  8. Non-Khmer speaking consultants will bear any translation costs
  9. Organize and facilitate a workshop to present findings and proposed recommendations and get feedback in order to finalize the report.
- Save the Children

Save the Children will assist the consultant(s) to ensure that the methodology and report is sound and meets the quality and requirements of Save the Children.

1. Review and provide feedback on inception report, tools, drafts, etc.
2. Assign staff to work with consultant during this process
3. Arrange appointments with relevant stakeholders
4. Provide any relevant documents to consultant
5. Approve payments for mid-term and final work progress for the consultancy.
6. Coordinate strategic engagement of MoSVY on methodology and final report
7. Coordinate the consultative workshop to get feedback on the drafted report

V. Deliverables

The consultancy work will be carried out during October-November 2021.

Key Tasks	Timeline	Estimated Days
1. Inception report with methodology, including sustainability' assessment tool, report content and assessment method.	11-13 Oct	3
2. Send out and collect inputs from FCF | REACT funded partners on the sustainability assessment tools	21-22 Oct	2
3. Initial analysis of sustainability assessment tool and design of questionnaire for KIIs.	25-29 Oct	5
4. Conduct KII and relevant institutions interview	08-13 Nov	6
5. Full draft report in English	Due 23 Nov	5
6. Organize and facilitate a workshop to present findings and to get feedback	25 Nov	1
7. Final report in English, data analysis/assessment sheet and final data collection tools.	Due 30 Nov	2
		TOTAL: 24 days

Note: Save the Children may modify these dates depending on donor requirements, delays in hiring, etc.

VI. Payment Schedule

Payment to the consultant shall be made in 3 instalments as below:

N	Outputs/Deliveries	Payment Schedule	Payment Amount
1	Completed and approved final inception report, including detailed methodology, work plan and data collection tools (deliverables 1)	1st payment	30%
2	Complete assessment and submit first draft report (deliverables 2-5)	2nd payment	50%
3	Organize and facilitate a final workshop to present findings and submit final report, data analysis/assessment sheet and final data collection tools (deliverable 6-7)	3rd payment	20%

The Royal Government of Cambodia requires a 14% withholding tax for non-residential consultants and a 15% withholding tax for residential consultants. This withholding tax will be withheld from the consultant's normal daily rate and is NOT the responsibility of Save the Children.

<u>Global criteria for deliverable satisfaction:</u>

A. For all deliverables and milestones, payment is not contingent upon simple completion of activities associated with deliverables and payment schedule, but rather the completion of the activity and deliverable to the satisfaction of Save the Children. Payment will be made based

on satisfactory passing of each milestone, including successful completion agreed follow up actions and tasks from previous month's appraisal.

B. Any analysis included should go beyond broad or general statements to make a specific argument justified by data with examples provided. This does not necessarily mean more pages, but rather specificity and justification.
    a. Example: 'migration is a major issue' (broad) versus 'migration affects shore-based communities more than floating communities, girls are more likely to be at-risk child migrants while boys are more likely to be children left behind, and while X organizations/government are addressing Y aspects of migration, no one is addressing Z aspects' (great!)

C. Any analysis should demonstrate a deep understanding of the child protection and welfare sector, and awareness of local and national contextual dynamics, including gender and poverty/vulnerability.
D. Any analysis should put forth recommendations justified by data or analysis. Where assertions are made, the evidence/data behind the assertion should be specified.
E. Any quantitative analysis involving comparisons between groups or relationships between variables must use statistical inference to draw conclusions. Results of statistical tests should be clearly marked in the report, using this system: ~p<0.1, *p<0.05, **p<0.01
F. The text accompanying figures and tables must go beyond listing of data points already visible in the figures/tables to synthesize the findings in terms of trends, patterns, unexpected findings, contrasts with other data, etc.
G. Deliverables should be written in clear, effective language and proof-read by a native English speaker for minimal grammar or spelling mistakes before draft submitted for Save the Children review.
H. Throughout the analysis and report writing process, relevant Save the Children in Cambodia staff have been engaged to the extent possible to build their capacity.

VII. Qualifications and requirements

- University degree in a relevant field
- Minimum of 5 years' experience in social work
- Demonstrated knowledge of relevant national and international standards on child welfare
- Demonstrated competence in quantitative and qualitative studies/ assessments, ideally with a focus on sustainability
- Strong analytical, synthesis, and writing skills
- Ability to work effectively with teams and with Government institutions and independently as appropriate
- Previous exposure to and experience in child protection programming, appropriate care programming desirable.
- Proven ability in computer skills and managing data
- Fluency in spoken and written English, and Khmer desirable

Management and Logistics

The consultant will report to the FCF|REACT Deputy Chief of Party.

Confidentiality

All data collected during this exercise will become the property of Save the Children and will not be shared with third parties without the express permission of Save the Children.

Other

Save the Children is committed to ensuring a safe environment and culture for all children with whom we come in contact during the course of our work. All external consultants involved in this evaluation exercise will be required to comply with Save the Children's Child Safeguarding Policy and sign the Code of Conduct.

Expressions of Interest

Suitably qualified and interested candidates are invited to submit to Save the Children Cambodia via jobs.cambodia@savethechildren.org by **23 Sept 2021.** Expressions of interest that do not cover the requirement below will not be considered:

- Capability statement (no more than 2 pages)
- A summarized CV
- Proposed budget
- Example of similar report/study produced in English, in which consultant is sole or lead author
- Contact information from two professional references related to similar pieces of work

VIII. This TOR is approved by:

Signature: _____

Name and Designation: Seang Meng, FCF|REACT Deputy Chief of Party

Date of Signing ……..July, 2021

Annex 2: Questionnaire for the Interviews

FCF | REACT Sustainability Study Questionnaire

	Question
	General
1.	What elements or components of the FCF REACT initiative do you consider it is **essential** to continue after the project ends? Why do you consider them to be essential?
2.	Are there any other elements or components of the FCF REACT initiative that it would be good to continue, if possible?
	Enabling conditions
3.	Are all the necessary laws, *Prakas*, etc in place for the work to continue? If no, what else is needed?
4.	What is your vision for the future of supporting family-based care work in Cambodia and who do you think should lead after the project ends?
5.	What do you think the future coordination structure should be to support what you believe to be the essential elements of the initiative? (If the respondent has added other elements in their answer to Q2, then follow up with 'Will this be sufficient to support the other elements that you think it would be good to continue?') The current structure (i.e. an INGO as LP doing the coordination) will need to change after the funding ends, what do you think the future structure should be?
6.	Are the current coordination and communication mechanisms enough and strong enough to take the work forward? If no, what needs to be put in place or strengthened?
7	What commitment can you/your organisation make to continuing the work after the project ends?
	Resources
8.	What resources – human, financial, technical or other – will your organisation be able to contribute to continuation of the work after the project ends?
9.	What resources will you need to be able to make that contribution? Where will you get them?
	Knowledge and skills
10.	Do you foresee any significant gaps in the knowledge and skills necessary to continue the work after the project ends? If yes, what needs to be put in place?
11.	How can the sector working on family-based care continue to learn to ensure that it remains technically up to date and is able to be flexible if circumstances change?
	Moving forward
12.	What opportunities does the end of the funded project offer to the sector working on family based care?
13.	What do you think will be the major challenges in making the results and work sustainable in future?
14.	What will be the best ways to overcome the challenges?

15.	What do you think are the important tasks that need to be taken in the next two years in order to ensure sustainability after the project ends?
16.	Who should be responsible for those tasks?
17.	Is there anything else that you think is important that has not been covered by the other questions?

Annex 3: List of Respondents

FCF REACT Sustainability Study Meetings Master List								
Key	**Respondent type:** GC = Central Government, GL = Local Government, 3PP = 3rd party partners, FCFP = FCF partners, D = donors, O = others							
	Gender: M - male, F = female							
Mtg #	**Resp. type**	**Name**	**Position**	**Organisation**	**Gender**	**Location**	**Date of meeting**	**Interviewer**
1	GL	H.E. Keo Rathdara	Deputy director of PP WCCC	PP Municipality	F	Phnom Penh	24/11/21	Chamroen
2	FCFP	Tang Sopheap	Programme Manager	TPO	F	Phnom Penh	25/11/21	Chamroen
3	3PP	Ung Pola	Programme Manager	Holt International	M	Phnom Penh	26/11/21	Chamroen
4	3PP	Chhay Vivodin	Executive Director	ISP Skillful Parenting	M	Phnom Penh	26/11/21	Chamroen
5	FCFP	Sok Chenda	Project officer	HAGAR	F	Phnom Penh	29/11/21	Chamroen
6	GL	Ms. Yem Dy	Second Deputy of Commune and CWCC	O Bak Roteas Commune	f	Kampon Seila District, SHV	29/11/21	Chamroen
7	GL	H.E. Prak Chansoka	CWCC Preah Sihanouk Province	SHV Province	F	Preah Sihanouk Council	30/11/21	Chamroen
8	GL	Mr. Horn Kim Hong	DoSVY (SHV Focal Person)	SHV DoSVY	M	Preah Sihanouk Province	30/11/21	Chamroen
9	GL	Ms. Meak Saroeun	Chief of Prey Non CWCC	Prey Nob District	F	Prey Nob District	12/01/2021	Chamroen
10	FCFP	Kieu Chetra	Programme Manager	Damnak Toek	M	Phnom Penh	12/02/2021	Chamroen
11	GL	Moeun Sokun	Chief of Child Wellfare Office, DoSVY (SR Fo	SR DoSAVY Office	M	Siem Reap Province	24/11/2021	Sokdeth
12	GL	H.E. Phavan Sakoeurt	Deputy of WCCC	BTB Provincial council	F	Battambang	29/11/2021	Sokchea
13	GL	Noun Kimsour	CCWC- Salakomroeuk Commune	Sala Kom Roeuk Commu	F	Siem Reap Province	25/11/2021	Sokdeth
14	GL	Ke Ya	CCWC-Roeul Commune	Roeul Commune	F	Siem Reap Province	25/11/2021	Sokdeth
15	GL	Ty Saran	CCWC- Sangkat Sras Chork	Online	F	Phnom Penh	28/11/2021	Sokdeth
16	GL	Khom Seihaneath	Chief of Child Wellfare Office, DoSVY Focal	DoSAVY-PP	F	Phnom Penh	29/11/2021	Sokdeth
17	GL	Bun Rumny	Vice-Chair WCCC-Kandal	Online	F	Kandal Province	29/11/2021	Sokdeth
18	3PP	Keir Drinnan	Managing Director	Cambodia Children Trust		Battambang	06/12/2021	Chamroen
19	GL	Phuong Sith	Head of Child Welfare Office	DoSAVY-BTB	M	Battambang	29/11/2021	Sokchea
20	GL	Sath Sithy	Office chief	DoSVY	M	Kandal Province	26/11/2021	Sokly
21	GL	Chum Vy	CWCC Takhmao Commune	Takhmao Commune	F	Kandal Province	28/11/2021	Sokly
22	GL	Ket Suntary	CWCC Preak Russey Commune	Preak Russey Commune	F	Kandal Province	29/11/2021	Sokly
23	GL	Her.E Sin Nom	Chair of WCCC-SR	SR Provincial Administra	F	Siem Reap Province	24/11/2021	Sokdeth
24	FCFP	Cheang Sovannarith	Social Workers	Mith Samlanh (FI)	M	Phnom Penh	12/07/2021	Chamroen
25	GL	Tem Sothy	CWCC Sangkat Phsar Doumthkov	Sangkat Phsar Doumthko	F	Phnom Penh	29/11/2021	Sokly
26	3PP	Phang Chanda	Children and family section lead	This life Cambodia	M	Siem Reap Province	29/11/2021	Sokly
27	FCFP	Prom Kim Chheng	Executive Director	Kumar Reakreay	F	Battambang province	06//12/2021	Sokly
28	FCFP	Hor Sokhors	Technical Director	CFI	M	Battambang province	06//12/2021	Sokly
29	D	Nouen Bou	Programme Officer	EU	M	Phnom Penh	01/12/2021	Jenny
30	D	Caitlyn McElroy	Children in Adversity and Education Advisor	USAID	F	Phnom Penh	06/12/2021	Jenny
31	O	Khadka Suman	Child Protection Specialist	UNICEF	F	Phnom Penh	07/12/2021	Jenny
32	3PP	Sarath Young	Programme Manager	First Step Camboda	M	Phnom Penh	07/12/2021	Jenny
33	FCFP	Prom Kim Chheng	Executive Director	KMR	F	BTB	12/06/2021	Sokdeth
34	GL	Hang Motha	CCWC	Anglong Vil commune	F	BTB	29/11/2021	Sokchea
35	GL	Nov Leakhena	ccwc	Sangkat Ou Char	F	BTB	29/11/2021	Sokchea
36	3PP	David Curties, Virak Kheng	Country Coordinator/Disability Inclusion Advisor, Senior Programme Manager	Light for the World	M	PP	08/12/2021	Jenny
37	LP	Bianca Collier, Leang Lo	COP, Head of Child Protection	SCI	F, M	PP	10/12/2021	Jenny
38	IP	Tho Maneth	Programme Director	Friends International	M	Siem Reap Province	12/10/2021	Chamroen

Annex 4: Sustainability Matrix

Necessary elements		Government - central	Government - local	3rd Party partners	FCF partners	Donors	Others
Enabling Conditions	Laws, Prakas, guidelines etc.						
	Vision and Leadership						
	Communication and Cooperation						
	Ownership and commitment						
Resources	Human						
	Financial						
	Technical						
Knowledge and Skills	Network facilitation (including communication)						
	Technical support						

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